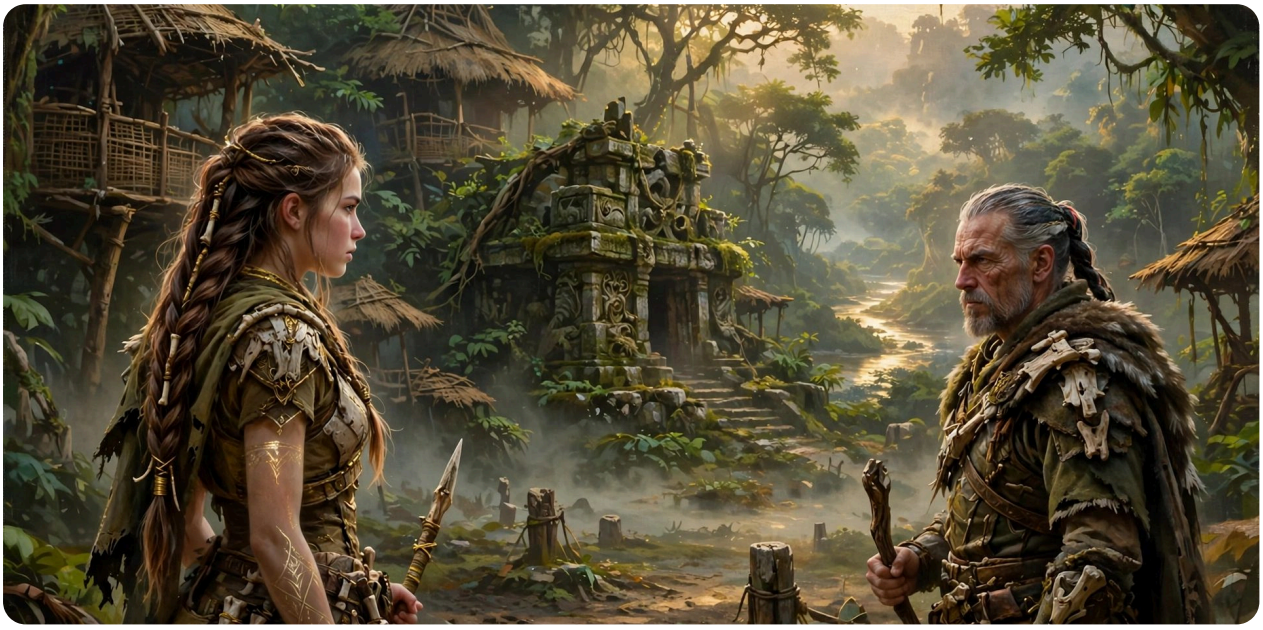
The First Hunt

Jabari's dawn test, and what waited beyond the clearing



Yara and Jabari on the training ground at dawn - the temple, the tree shelters, and the river behind them.

Yara is seventeen, half human and half Vey'kar. Yesterday Amara taught her to dim her markings, and Zola ran her ragged across the training ground. Last night, Jabari gave her an order disguised as a remark: dawn, the training ground. Today the elder stops watching - and starts testing. And beyond the clearing, on her first real hunt, Yara's senses find something in the jungle that should not be there at all.

Yara was early, and it did not help her at all.

She had woken in the dark with her shoulder aching from Amara's paste, a blister from the shelter work stinging on her palm, and one clear thought sitting on her chest like a stone: dawn, the training ground. She had dressed without waking her mother - or so she believed, until Oya, without opening her eyes, her voice low and still thick with sleep but quite awake underneath, said, “Eat something first. Pride is not food,” and Yara had taken a cold mouthful of last night's root cake mainly so that no one could say, afterwards, that she had been warned. She swallowed the cake with her jaw tight, annoyed at being known so well, and steadied by it too - even half-asleep, her mother missed nothing.

The clearing was grey and empty. Mist sat low over the training ground, between the practice posts, in a way that made the whole place look underwater. Yara stood in the middle of it feeling extremely visible and tried Amara's breathing, the way she had been taught. Out, long, through the nose. Put down the feeling that feeds it. Her markings, which had been shining cheerfully since she woke, sank by about the width of a hair and stopped, as if to see whether she meant it. Her hands hung at her sides, fingers curling and uncurling. She was afraid of looking foolish, and suspected that fear was exactly what was shining.

“You breathe like a girl counting,” said Jabari, dry and unhurried, from the mist behind her, not troubling to raise his voice at all.

Yara did not jump. She was very proud, for about one second, of not jumping. Then her markings flared so bright that the mist in front of her lit faintly blue, and Jabari made a small sound in his throat - not a laugh, exactly, but the place where a laugh would go, in a colder man.

He had been there before her. Of course he had. There was dew on his shoulders that said he had been standing in the mist a long while, and his short spear was planted in the earth beside him, and he looked, as he always looked, like weather that had already decided.

Yara lifted her chin and kept her voice level, though her throat had gone tight. “Elder,” Yara said, with a small, stiff dip of her head.

“Princess,” he said, looking at her steadily, his own markings dark and still, giving nothing away. “You are wondering what the test is. Everyone wonders. Your mother wondered, in this same mist, at about your age, and she had better manners than to ask.” He pulled his spear free in one clean motion and let the point rest toward the ground, saying it flatly, as if the ground itself were the judge and he only its messenger. “The test is the ground. Cross it.”

“Cross it how?” Yara asked, before she could stop herself, her hands fisting at her sides in embarrassment the moment the words were out.

“So that I do not know you crossed it,” Jabari said, evenly, as if he were describing the weather. He let a pause sit there, so she could feel the size of the task. “Cloaked. Silent. No light. From that post to the far root, and back if you are feeling decorated. I will not watch you.” He turned his back on her, deliberately, and folded his arms. “A hunter is found by ears and noses long before eyes, princess. Eyes are the last sense to save you and the first one the young rely on. Begin.”

Yara pulled the light-weave cloak around her and settled it the way Zola had shown her, feeling for the familiar, slippery moment when the light began to bend. It came. The posts, the mist, Jabari's broad back - all of it went slightly watery at the edges of her sight, which meant it was working. She breathed out. She took one step, soft as falling ash.

A dry leaf, hidden under the wet ones, cracked under her heel like a small bone.

“Dead,” said Jabari, flat as a stone dropping, without turning round - his shoulders did not even move. “Again.”

The second crossing went better, and then worse. She got halfway - halfway, farther than she had ever managed moving - before Jabari said, conversationally, to the mist - too conversationally, a needle slid in sideways while he kept his eyes on the fog, so she would hear it clean, “Your father, I am told, could not do this at all. No markings to dim. No cloak that would hold for him. A human, trying to walk like us, in our own trees.” Her heart slammed. Shame and anger went through her together, hot and confused - shame that it was true, anger that he had chosen it for a weapon. The cloak shivered, thinned, and gave her back to the morning in pieces - a shoulder, a hand, a braid full of traitor light - and the leaf litter announced the rest.

“Dead,” Jabari said, without pity and without pleasure. “And angry. Anger is loud, princess. It breathes for you and it shines for you, and every hungry thing for a mile learns your name.” He turned round at last, slowly, and let her see his face was grave. There was no triumph in his face, and somehow that was worse than triumph. “Amara taught you to put the feeling down. I am teaching you what the feeling costs. There is a difference, and the difference is the whole lesson.”

Yara stood in the open with her cloak hanging off one shoulder and said nothing, because everything she wanted to say was loud, and she was beginning to understand that he knew it. She pressed her lips together and stared at the ground between her feet, breathing until the wish to shout went thin.

She crossed on the third try.

Not because she stopped feeling anything. That was the trick she had been getting wrong since Amara's hut - she had been trying to go empty, and empty was a lid on a boiling pot, and lids rattle. This time she let the anger be there, low and ordinary, like the ache in her shoulder - noticed, named, and not fed. Out, long, through the nose. She chose the wet line of leaves, where the mist had soaked everything soft. She moved only when the morning birds moved, in their noise, under their cover. Jabari's back stayed turned. The far root came up under her hand, cool and real as a held breath. Relief rose in her so bright she had to breathe it down too, quickly, before it could shine.

“And back?” he said, still without turning, a thread of dry amusement in it now. “If you are feeling decorated.”

Yara nearly laughed, which would have killed her a fourth time. She swallowed it down to a warmth instead, and crossed back inside the sound of the river, and stopped, breathing carefully through a grin she did not let happen, at the end, close enough to see the dew beading on Jabari's spear shaft.

“Alive,” he said, at last, with a single short nod - the smallest coin he had. “Once. A beginning has been made. Do not frame it.”

Then he did something she had not expected. He crouched, and with two fingers drew a line in the damp earth - a trail sign, then a second sign crossing it out, then a third she did not know. “Zola reads the ground with her feet,” he said, still drawing, not looking up, his big hand surprisingly delicate in the dirt. “She smells a trail the way you smell rain. You will not beat her at it, so do not try. You read people, princess. I have watched you do it since you were small enough to hide in a grain basket. You knew I would speak of your father before I spoke. So. Think like the one who laid the trail, and your feet will have less work to do.”

Yara crouched beside him without being asked, her braid swinging forward, and traced the lines with one fingertip, following his thought with her hand. It was the closest thing to a compliment Jabari had ever given her, delivered like an insult, which made it safe to accept. The third sign, stared at, gave up its meaning: a false line, laid to be followed, over the true one, laid to be missed.

“You think everything is a test,” she said, looking up at him, half accusing and half - to her own surprise - almost fond.

“No,” said Jabari, standing and brushing the dirt from his fingers against his thigh, his markings catching the first light and then settling, controlled as ever, as the first true light found the top of the canopy. “I think everything is a hunt, and a test is only a hunt where someone tells you the rules first. Come. Zola is waiting at the east trail, and she has been awake since before either of us, telling the trees about it.”

Oya was waiting at the east trail too, which Zola said was cheating.

“Queens are allowed,” Oya said, mildly, the corner of her mouth moving, her markings calm and even. She looked Yara over once - cloak, knife, short spear, water skin, the wrap of dried food Zola had thrust at her - and then, more carefully, she looked at Jabari. Some whole conversation passed between the two of them in that look, in the language of people who had been student and teacher long before Yara was born, and Yara, who could read people, could not read a word of it. It annoyed her more than she expected. Behind her mother's calm, Yara thought, Oya was weighing something heavier than a hunt - a worry she held where no one else had to carry it, the way she held everything.

“The pot is low,” Oya said at last, turning to face all three of them squarely, her voice going from mother to queen between one breath and the next. “Take what the code allows and no more. Close the trail behind you, every time, as if your lives hang on it - they do, only slowly. And hear me, all three of you. Word before meat. If anything out there is wrong, you come home and say it first, and we will eat roots and be glad of them. Is that understood?”

“Yes,” Zola and Yara said together - Zola at once, chin up, Yara a fraction later, earnest and trying not to show it - and Jabari said nothing, which from Jabari was a kind of yes with seniority.

Beyond the clearing, the jungle changed its mind about them. Inside Kijani's ground everything was known - every root had a use, every sound had a name and an owner. Out here the green was older, thicker, and entirely indifferent, and Yara loved it with a quick, guilty fierceness and kept that love dim and down, the way she had been taught, like everything else bright in her.

They moved in a line, Jabari first, Yara in the middle where the lesson could reach her, Zola last and everywhere at once. Hand signs did the talking: stop, scent, listen, down. Twice Jabari froze the line for dangers Yara only understood afterwards - a snake asleep in the exact brown of the leaf litter, a wasps' nest hanging low and humming like a plucked string. Once, Zola reached past Yara without a word and moved her foot, mid-step, three inches to the left of a root that would have cracked. All the while Zola kept glancing back the way they had come, covering the rear without being told, loyal as a shadow.

“You always do that for me,” Yara whispered, ducking under a low frond, startled and grateful.

“Yesterday was a game,” Zola whispered back, catching Yara's elbow to steady her past the root, and for the first time since Yara had known her, there was no grin in it at all. “This is dinner. And dinner out here can have opinions.”

The boar announced itself the way the old one had, on Yara's first morning: by standing very still, a long way off, being a tree so hard that it gave itself away.

“There,” she breathed, freezing mid-step, one finger raised and her other hand flat in the signal for stillness, and Jabari's head turned, slow, to follow her pointing finger. “Past the fallen palm. It knows something is here. It has not decided what.”

“She is right,” Zola said, surprised and pleased, from behind her, giving Yara's shoulder a quick, proud squeeze as the word passed forward.

They worked closer the way weather moves in - nothing hurrying, the distance closing in small, patient taxes of ground. Yara read the sign as it came: a rubbed stump, mud still wet at the wallow's edge, the sharp, warm smell of the animal under the green rot of the floor. Her senses, which had embarrassed her all morning, out here simply did their work. Her heart went hard and steady. Her markings held low. This, she thought, is what the breathing was for.

Then, through a gap in the ferns, she saw the boar clearly - and saw the rest of it, and stopped so suddenly that Zola nearly walked through her.

It was a sow - and pressed along her far side were three striped shapes, small as cats, still wobbly on legs the world had only just lent them. The sow's head was up and turning, turning, trying to keep the whole jungle in her eyes at once, because everything in it now had to be measured against them.

Yara's spear felt suddenly stupid in her hand. A protectiveness she had not expected rose in her, sudden and complete. She lowered it before she had decided to.

She waited for Jabari to overrule her. Hunters had come out for the pot. Queens had spoken of low stores. The law she had been raised on said a hunter provides, and does not go home telling stories about why not. She braced for the lesson - and Jabari, beside her, already had his own spear down, and was watching not the sow at all, but Yara's face, the way he watched weather. In his stillness she felt, rather than saw, that he would not take the sow either - his disapproval was reserved for the alternative, and he was waiting to hear her say why.

“Say it,” he murmured, barely moving his lips, his eyes still on the sow, leaving her the space to find the words herself.

“We do not take her,” Yara said, her voice low and unsteady at first. “Never hunt the weak. She is not weak - she is -” she searched, her free hand opening and closing at her side, and found it, “- she is spoken for. By them. Taking her takes four, and leaves three to die slowly, and that is not a clean hunt. That is just killing, wearing a hunt's clothes.” Her breath came out shaky. She had said it - whatever he answered, she had said it standing up.

“Respect your prey,” Jabari said, very quietly, with something in his face that was almost approval, banked down at once like a coal covered in ash. “You recite it better with a spear in your hand than most do at a fire. Down. Let her keep her morning.”

They withdrew the way they had come, in silence, and Yara was half-way back through the ferns - the pot still low, the hunt already over - when she heard the sound that did not belong to the jungle at all.

It was thin. It was wrong in its rhythm. A scrabbling, then a stop. A scrabbling, then a stop, in a pattern that repeated too exactly, like something counting. And under it, so faint that her human ears would have missed it and her other ears could not, a creaking that was not wood and not vine. Every part of her was listening; even her breathing went shallow and slow.

Yara raised a closed fist. Jabari froze. Zola froze behind her, mid-breath.

“Not prey the way we mean it,” Yara whispered, her voice shaking only slightly, her eyes already searching the shadows below the trail. “Something held.”

It was a young deer, down in a shallow gully, held by a loop of bright wire around one hind leg, pulled up short against a bent sapling. The wire was not woven, grown, carved, or knotted by any hand that belonged in the green place. It was twisted, clean and even, in a way that spoke of tools and shops - and it had already cut through the deer's skin, a little more with every counted scrabble.

The deer saw them and went still, spending the last of itself on being stone. Its eye was huge and dark and fixed on Yara.

“Do not go straight to it,” Zola said, barely voiced, one hand lifted, palm out, in warning - fear for Yara plain underneath the steadiness she was forcing into her voice. “An animal held like that will break its own leg to get away from you. Princess. Yara. What are you doing.”

“What the code says,” Yara said, more calmly than she felt, her heart going hard against her ribs. She set her spear down in the leaves, slow, where the deer could watch her do it. “It is weak. It is held. No hunter of ours made this, which makes it our business twice over. Jabari?” She did not turn round. She could feel him deciding. Her voice, when it came, was quiet and very clear, and it cost her to keep it so. “Elder. I am not asking you to approve of me. I am asking whether I am wrong.”

A long silence, in which the wire creaked once, not wood and not vine.

“You are not wrong,” Jabari said, gravely, with a weight in it that told her he had weighed her, and not just the deer. “Now do it as if you meant to succeed.”

Freeing the deer took longer than killing it would have. Everything right that day seemed built that way: slower than the wrong thing, and costing more.

Zola circled wide and came in downwind, cloak half-raised, talking in the low, nonsense croon she also used on frightened children. Jabari held the sapling's strain off with his spear shaft so the wire hung slack. And Yara, on her knees in the mud, worked her knife under the loop a hair's width at a time, breathing out, long, through her nose, keeping her heart - and her light - down where the deer would not have to fear them. Her fingers, muddy and careful, trembled once and then steadied. In her head was Amara's voice, patient as ever, as if the healer had known this exact moment was coming when she taught her the breathing.

“If you cut me,” she told it, quietly, keeping her eyes soft and her hands slower still, half plea and half joke to keep her own fear down, “I will understand, and Amara will not.”

The wire parted with a small, bright sound. The deer stood for one disbelieving second, put weight on the freed leg, found it still answered, and went - not gracefully, not fast, but away, crashing once through fern, then finding its quiet and taking it.

“It will limp,” Zola said, wincing down at the cut, her usual grin nowhere to be found, rough with a worry she covered by being practical. “It may still die of that cut, out there -”

“It may live,” Jabari said, cutting across her, firm as a hand on a shoulder, and he looked at Yara as he said it, not at Zola. “Which it was not going to do, hanging on a human's wire. Count the difference, tracker, and hold your tongue.”

Human. He said it plainly, to the empty gully, and nobody argued with the word. Yara turned the cut wire over in her hands. It was smooth. It was new. Its end had been snipped by a tool that cut metal the way teeth cut fruit, and the sapling it was tied to had been chosen with a hunter's eye - on a game trail, above water, where thirst would do the waiting for you.

Then Zola went still, in a way Yara had learned to dread, one finger pointing without her arm seeming to move, her voice dropping to almost nothing. “There is another one.”

The second snare hung empty fifty paces on, along the same faint game trail, its loop open and patient at ankle height. Beside its sapling, a vine had been cut through in one clean stroke - not torn, not chewed, cut - to clear the line of the trap. One snare might be a lost thing, a stray thing, a thing washed or carried in from the world beyond the trees. Two snares in a line, on a trail, cleared and kept, were a sentence written in the jungle by someone who intended to come back and read it.

Jabari took the second snare down himself, with a care Yara had never seen him use, and coiled both wires into his hunting wrap as if they were evidence - which they were.

“The hunt is over,” he said, in a tone that ended all discussion. “Word before meat. Your mother was not speaking in poetry.” No one suggested the sow again. They went home with empty hands, covering their trail at every turn - and for the first time Yara did that work understanding it from the other side, as the thing standing between Kijani and a pair of patient, twisted wires.

Oya did not raise her voice when they laid the coils before her on the temple steps. She picked one up and held it a long time, looking at the clean-cut end and the even twist. Her fingers were not quite steady; she stilled them - fear for half a breath, and guilt that her village might not be hidden enough - then the queen again.

“How far?” she asked, very quietly, looking only at Jabari.

“Half a morning,” Jabari said, choosing each word the way he chose footing. “Far enough to be carelessness. Near enough to stop being only that, if the line walks this way.”

“Then the trails will be walked,” Oya said, her voice level and carrying, giving orders she wished she did not have to give. “All of them, tonight, quietly. No talk of it at the fire.” She set the wire down in the centre of the stone, as if it were a small, dead, poisonous thing. Only then did she look at her daughter, and her face softened and tightened at once, pride and worry together. “Empty-handed.” She said it without blame, which made Yara feel it more.

“There was a sow, with young,” Yara said, the words tumbling out too fast, her markings flaring with shame, her hands twisting together. “And then - this. I freed what it was holding. I know the pot is low, I know we came back with nothing to -”

“You came back with the word,” Oya said, and laid a brief hand on Yara's arm - warm, firm, gone before it could become comfort in front of the elder. “Which is what I sent you for.” She turned to go, and stopped, and spoke half over her shoulder. “Jabari. Your verdict.”

The elder looked at Yara in that level, wintry way he had, as if reading weather far away - and for once, it seemed to satisfy him.

“Dawn,” he said, already walking away down the steps, not looking back. “The training ground. Same time.” And as he passed Yara, not stopping, he added, low, for her and Oya alone: “She did the day's real work, Oya. I said it once. Do not ask me to repeat it.”

That night Yara ate roots at the fire and was glad of them, as her mother had promised, and the bright wire sat in the dark of Oya's hut, saying everything. She was proud, and she was frightened, and tired to her bones under both.

End of Chapter 3

Jabari has tested Yara and - in his own way, once, and not to be repeated - said she passed the part that mattered. But the hunt gave Kijani something no one wanted: proof, in bright cut wire, that human hands have been setting snares half a morning from the hidden village.

Next: Chapter 4 - The trails are walked by night and Oya keeps the village calm, while Yara is trusted with work that is no longer practice - and wonders who sets a line of snares, and then comes back to check it.

Book plan: 20 chapters, about 250 pages - Act 1 is Chapters 1-5, Act 2 is Chapters 6-14, Act 3 is Chapters 15-20. Chapters 1-3 are now written. Series: *Yara of Kijani*. Book 1: *Daughter of Two Worlds*.